

The dark water surrounding the island is a transplanted portion of the River Styx, ritually summoned by the now-dead merrenoloth commander of the yugoloth strike team as a way to quarantine the island. The Styx sea is weaker than the pure River Styx, but it still radiates evil and magic. Small quantities of holy water poured upon it instantly turn to steam and evaporate.

A creature that is lightly splashed by or exposed to the water suffers no ill effects. But any creature other than a fiend, a construct, or a plant creature that is immersed in the water or that drinks it must attempt a DC 15 Intelligence saving throw. With a success, the creature feels a dark, sleepy sensation that threatens to pull its memories away but quickly fades. On a failed save, the creature's Intelligence and Charisma scores become 5 (if they were not already lower) and it loses all memories of its life. At the same time, all curses, diseases, and magical effects currently in effect upon the creature (including the pixelating curse) are ended.

A character who falls victim to the Styx sea's effects takes on the mentality of a young, meek child. They can speak haltingly, but they have total amnesia and cannot recognize their friends—and might even forget the function of common objects. If attacked, a victim's muscle memory kicks in and they are able to defend themselves with weapons. But a victim of the Styx sea cannot cast spells, concentrate on spells or other effects, use class features, employ magic items, or undertake any other complex action, at your determination.

A *greater restoration* spell restores a victim's ability scores and memory. Failing that, a victim's Intelligence and Charisma go up by 2 points at the end of each long rest, until their original scores are regained. As a victim regains its ability scores, it gradually regains its memories and features as well, with the amnesia ending when the creature's ability scores are restored to normal.

INVISIBLE GUARDIANS

Three **hydroloths**SM lurk invisibly in the Styx sea, guarding the island so that no creatures leave it that might spread the **pixelating curse**. Any character who succeeds on a DC 20 Wisdom (Perception) check while scanning the black water can see the telltale ripples of large shapes moving therein. If the check result is 25 or higher, the observer makes out three invisible shapes that are human-sized and that swim more like giant frogs than fish—and that slowly move to intercept the characters' ship.

The hydroloths were ordered to guard the island by their commanders—the oinoloth and the late merrenoloth that went onto face 5 of the cube with a force of other hydroloths and never returned. They know that the oinoloth must still be alive because they've seen the vampiric mists drifting through the fog that covers the island (see the *censer of blood* in the "New Magic Items" appendix). However, they have no idea as to the other yugoloths' fate.

If a ship observes the island from a distance, the hydroloths watch but leave it alone. Only if a ship



makes a close approach or a creature flies or teleports from the ship to the island do they react, attempting to scuttle the ship if it touches the island, or boarding it, killing the crew, and leaving it adrift if it doesn't. The hydroloths won't pursue creatures onto the cube. They know from experience that touching the cube for a short period probably won't pixelate them, but they're scared to risk it.

If the characters don't flee at once, the hydroloths use their telepathy to communicate with them, recognizing that powerful adventurers might be of use to them. The fiends can explain the fog (see below), the pixelating curse, the Styx sea, and the outer workings of the island—in exchange for a promise that the characters will try to locate and aid any surviving yugoloths currently within the cube.

The hydroloths make whatever slippery promises they can in an attempt to win the characters' assistance, though they have no intention of keeping those promises. However, they can share other useful intelligence, including that the yugoloth strike team went ashore on the beautiful island (face 5), and that the fiends carried a number of valuable magic items the characters are welcome to if their owners have met their end. (They don't bother telling the characters that the oinoloth will ultimately claim all such treasures for itself, killing the characters once the rescue is done.)

DERELICT DROW GALLEY

Not far from the island, an abandoned drow galley—a black and lavender trireme once rowed by chained slaves—floats aimlessly through the fog. The ship is built on four levels: the main deck (exposed to the weather), the cannon deck (where the main cabins are located), the rowers' deck, and the cargo hold. Its three banks of oars suggest that the huge ship should have a crew of over one hundred. But there is no sign of motion

on the deck, the sails are torn, and numerous oars have been shattered.

Characters who approach to within 30 feet of the ship become suddenly aware of the telepathic presence of other creatures. Three entities contact three individual characters, crying out in rage as they demand to be freed from something. The characters can respond to the pleas, but the nature of telepathic communications gives them no hint that these creatures are three *bulezau* demons. Likewise, the demons keep that information to themselves as they plead for the characters' aid. The *bulezaus* are imprisoned in a magic pentagram in a cabin on the ship's cannon deck. See *Mordenkainen's Tome of Foes* for details of the *bulezau*.

FATE OF THE DROW

The ship was captained by a drow named Simak, who used the advice of a drow oracle to seek out a "great weapon" that had fallen to the Material Plane from Acheron. After determining the dangers of the Styx sea when one crew member lost his memory after being exposed to the black water, a drow force went ashore on face 4 of the island under command of Simak and a high priestess, leaving guards and galley slaves behind.

The landing party were all promptly killed or captured by the skull lord's forces. Vargo tried to take the high priestess's skull, but failed when she killed herself first. Meanwhile, the drow forces and galley slaves on the ship were killed by the hydroloths. Simak, the last survivor of the drow expedition, escaped death at Vargo's hands by pretending to be under the effects of the Styx sea, and now lives in the complex under face 6, desperately plotting her escape.

MAIN DECK

This deck holds the ship's two masts, a small empty forecabin and aftercabin, and three sets of stairs leading down open hatches into the decks below. The whole deck is strewn with the gory remnants of a battle: bloodstains (drow, killed by the hydroloths), scattered weapons, some stained with a foul ichor (the hydroloths' blood), and piles of mingled hydroloth vomit and drow bones. A close investigation discerns the bodies of ten to twenty individual drow. The prints of huge frog-like creatures (the hydroloths) cover the deck.

Between the central hatch and the starboard rail, the ship's fungus-wood timbers are damaged and streaked with foul-smelling slime. A successful DC 15 Wisdom (Survival) check determines that some large creature crawled out of the hatch and went overboard. (This was the balhannoth, currently on face 5 of the cube).

The *bulezaus'* telepathy has a range of 60 feet, and can be heard from anywhere on the ship.

CANNON DECK

The cannon deck consists of a set of cabins to aft and a large open area containing sixteen cannons (see "Siege Equipment" in chapter 8 of the *Dungeon Master's Guide*). The iron cannons are carved with spiders, demons, and gargoyles.

In the aft cannon deck, beyond a short corridor, are the cabins of the captain, the first mate, and the high

priestess of Lolth. One wall of the corridor features what appears to be a thick growth of fungus. In truth, this is an alkilith demon grown from spores released when the ship was abandoned. (See *Mordenkainen's Tome of Foes* for details of the alkilith.)

Fiendish Ambush. The *alkilith* resembles a fungal growth eating into the wood of the ship. It is visually indistinguishable from a slime or fungus, but its fiendish nature can be noted with a *detect evil and good* spell or similar ability, and it responds if attacked. If its true nature is not revealed, the alkilith waits for the characters to get close so that its Foment Madness can confuse at least one of them. It then attacks at will.

First Mate's Cabin. These utilitarian sailor's quarters contain nothing of value.

High Priestess's Cabin. A rotten stench is noticed by anyone approaching the door to this area. The finely furnished room is decorated with black and red spider-silk tapestries (1,000 gp). On the floor is a large chalk pentagram in which three hungry *bulezaus*^M are imprisoned.

Summoned just before the drow went to the island—then forgotten here when the ship was attacked by the hydroloths—the *bulezaus* cannot escape unless the chalk pentagram is broken from outside. When they see the characters, their telepathic demands for aid become more agitated. The demons make any promises to secure their escape, but they immediately break those oaths and try to eat their rescuers if freed. Any character proficient in the Arcana skill knows that attacking the *bulezaus* from outside the pentagram will break its magic and release them.

Even if the pentagram isn't broken, the characters are still subject to the *bulezaus'* Rotting Presence feature. It takes 5 rounds under the effects of Rotting Presence to fully search the cabin for the treasure found here—a pouch holding thirty-two bloodstone, onyx, and sardonyx gems (50 gp each); various ritual devices and candles (100 gp); a *+3 dagger*; and a *cloak of the bat*.

Captain's Cabin. Decorated in white and cream puffball colors with coral-like fungus candelabra, this area contains the ship's charts and the captain's log (written in Elvish). The charts show that the ship originated in the Underdark, traveling to the sea by way of secret underground rivers. They are worth 500 gp to a sage or a well-heeled Underdark explorer.

The log identifies the ship's commander as Simak, the head of a minor drow noble house. Two weeks earlier, a drow oracle told her that a great weapon had fallen out of Acheron, crashing from the Nine Hells to the Material Plane. The weapon is described as a giant battle station—a flying fortress of immense power with cannons that can destroy cities. Simak quickly gathered a secret expedition to find this weapon, seeking to increase the glory of her house. The last entry in the log identifies this mysterious weapon as the island, confirming that it had been sighted, and that the crew were planning to go ashore.

The cabin also contains a *+1 shortsword*, a *potion of vitality*, 800 gp, and a collection of fine spider-shell dishware worth 1,200 gp.

ROWER'S DECK

The bodies of over a hundred unfortunate human, kuo-toa, and myconid galley slaves are still chained to rows of filthy benches, where they were killed by the hydroloths. Near the central hatch, the bodies have been dismembered in gruesome and imaginative ways. Toward the edges of the fray, they are each killed with a single blow to the head or chest, as if whoever massacred them began to grow bored.

CARGO HOLD

A rank smell fills this area, and can be noted by characters as they descend the stairs. The hold contains barrels of food, fresh water, and fungus wine, along with nonmagical weapons and armor, rope, sailcloth, glowing fungus lamps, and other supplies.

In the center of the hold is a great 10-foot-by-10-foot iron cage, empty and seemingly melted open. Foul-smelling lavender slime sticks to the bars of the cage, and drips along a trail of damaged floorboards leading to the stairs below the main hatch. Iron amulets bearing the mark of Lolth are bolted to the sides of the cage. A successful DC 20 Intelligence (Arcana) check recognizes them as wards against transmutation, though their magic has failed. The cage once contained Simak's 'pet'—a balhannoth that escaped to the island after the rest of the crew was killed, and which now lairs on face 5.

EXPLORING THE ISLAND

If the characters drop a line or an anchor to test the depth of the water near the island, they don't find bottom. The island seems to rise vertically out of the depths like a plateau, giving no sign that it's floating. Its edges are like a short cliff that rises out of the water, but any character who inspects the edge or has a passive Wisdom (Perception) score of 15 or higher notes something disturbing.

Where the dark waves crash against the cliff, an irregularity appears in the stone, with the rectangular terraces seeming to break down into something like mangrove roots or coral. Getting close enough for a careful inspection reveals what those 'roots' truly are—uncountable close-stacked bodies that are piled over one another as they disappear into the black depths.

This grotesque vision appears because the black Styx water dispels the pixelating curse. Where the upper surface of the cube is exposed to air, it is pixelated. Where the other faces are under the Styx sea, they return to their original form of iron covered by the fallen dead.

RANDOM ISLAND MISHAPS

All the ground on the island is difficult terrain. For each 10 minutes that a character spends walking around, they must make a successful DC 10 Dexterity saving throw. On a failure, roll a d6 to determine the outcome.

1—Spikey Step. The character impales their foot on something that looks like a three-foot-long spike of shining gray shale, which deals 3 (1d6) piercing damage and breaks away from the ground. The spike is a longsword. Close examination shows that despite

appearing to be made of cubes, the spike's tip and sides are extremely sharp.

2—Unexpected Fall. The character falls down a previously unseen hole and is trapped by something that feels like thick roots. With a successful DC 10 Wisdom (Perception) check, the character realizes that the roots are the cold, clammy arms and legs of the dead. The character is restrained, but can escape or be lifted out with a successful DC 12 Strength (Athletics) check.

3—Slippery Slope. A chunk of hillside collapses under the character, who falls prone and takes 2 (1d4) bludgeoning damage. The ground breaks apart into six-foot-long, log-like chunks—a number of bodies that roll downhill before coming to a stop.

4—Cubed Loot. The character trips across a gray metallic object that separates itself from the ground and can be picked up. If the characters wash the object in the Styx sea or see it through *pixel glasses* (see the "New Magic Items" appendix), roll a d6 to see what it is:

d6	Object
1	A silver bracelet worth 75 gp
2	A small platinum idol of Bhaal worth 300 gp
3	A silver-plated githyanki hand worth 200 gp, and which can be used to open the locks of the doors into and inside the cube (see "Exterior Doors")
4	A silver medallion worth 125 gp
5	A figurine of wondrous power—silver raven
6	A cursed amulet resembling a medusa's face. The amulet petrifies any creature within 30 feet of it that looks at it, as if the creature were targeted by a <i>flesh to stone</i> spell (save DC 15). The amulet has AC 15 and 10 hit points. If it is broken, any creatures it has petrified or restrained have those conditions ended.

5—Foul Slime. The character steps into something soft, releasing black pixelated slime and a foul smell. The character and all other creatures within 10 feet of them must succeed on a DC 10 Constitution saving throw or be poisoned for 1 minute or until they intentionally vomit as an action.

6—Armor Pile. A character slips on an area of metallic gray cubes, rectangles, and tubes (a pile of weapons and armor stripped from the dead). The character falls prone and takes 2 (1d4) bludgeoning damage.

MYSTERIOUS FOG

The eerie fog that surrounds the island rises 100 feet above the water and extends 1,000 feet across. The area of the fog is lightly obscured, and it has a red tinge in places. Creatures that suffer negative effects in sunlight ignore those effects on the surface of the island while the fog is present.

A successful DC 10 Intelligence (Nature) check confirms that the fog is supernatural in origin, though it creates no ill effects. But the fog hides a deadly threat in the form of the red-tinged areas within it, which manifest in response to any creature that first sets foot on the island, then flies while on its surface. The first creature to do so is attacked by seven **vampiric mists**^M created by the oinoloth's *censer of blood* (see the "New Magic Items" appendix). One mist attacks the first